

Instagram & Facebook Parent Guide

What changed in the 2026 Teen Accounts settlement, and every setting worth checking
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WHY THIS GUIDE EXISTS NOW

Following an August 2026 litigation settlement, Meta is actively rolling new limits into every Instagram and Facebook account it identifies as belonging to someone under 18 — not a future promise, a change happening on your teen's phone right now. That makes this the first moment a parent guide to these apps is actually worth writing: the defaults changed, and most parents (and most teens) don't yet know what the new defaults are.

 **Important:** Age is Meta's own self-reported signal at signup. If your teen entered a false birthdate years ago, none of these teen protections apply automatically — check Step 1 first.

STEP 1 — CONFIRM THE ACCOUNT IS ACTUALLY A TEEN ACCOUNT

- 1 On your teen's device: Settings → Account type and tools → confirm it says "Teen Account," not a regular adult account
- 2 If it's not a Teen Account, the birthdate on file is wrong — Meta requires a correction before teen protections apply
- 3 Teen Accounts are private by default — confirm the profile isn't set to public

STEP 2 — CHECK THE NEW TIME & CURFEW LIMITS

Teen Accounts now default to a **2-hour/day** time limit on Instagram and Facebook, plus an automatic overnight block.

- 1 Settings → Time management → confirm the daily limit is active (default 2 hours)
- 2 A parent can raise or remove this limit via Parental Supervision (Step 3) — decide together whether to change it, don't just silently override it
- 3 Confirm the overnight block (midnight–6am) is on — during this window the app pushes teens toward logging off
- 4 Notifications are blocked 8am–3pm on school days by default — a real reduction in the "phone buzzing in class" problem

STEP 3 — LINK PARENTAL SUPERVISION

Meta's parent-visibility tool for these apps. Like Discord's Family Center, it's consent-based — your teen has to accept the link — which keeps it honest rather than covert.

- 1 Parent: Settings → Family Center → Supervision → send a request to your teen's account
- 2 Once accepted, you can see time spent, who they follow/who follows them, and adjust the time limit
- 3 You'll now be alerted if your teen opens a new account, or is contacted by an adult account Meta has flagged as suspicious

 **Tip:** Tell your teen directly: "I'll see the shape of your account — time spent, who you follow — not your DMs or what you post. If that ever changes, I'll tell you first."

STEP 4 — KNOW THE REPORTING PROMISE (AND WHERE IT FALLS SHORT)

Meta has pledged to respond to **90%** of teen-submitted abuse reports within 6 hours — a real, testable commitment. Teach your teen to actually use the in-app report button rather than just blocking and moving on, since a block alone doesn't flag the account for anyone else.

STEP 5 — WARNING SIGNS TO WATCH FOR

- A second, hidden account ("finsta") — often a sign the visible account is being kept curated for a parent
- An online "friend" or follower they've never met, especially one who asks to move the conversation to DM or another app
- Requests for photos, or pressure to keep a friendship secret from you — always a red flag
- Sudden secrecy about the phone, or anxiety after checking the app
- Comments or DMs involving money, gifts, or "modeling"/"collab" offers from strangers

STEP 6 — HOW TO REPORT & BLOCK

Block: open their profile → the three dots → "Block." **Report a post, DM, or account:** the three dots on that item → "Report." **Report to law enforcement:** for suspected grooming, sextortion, or exploitation, also file with the FBI (tips.fbi.gov) or NCMEC's CyberTipline (CyberTipline.org) — an in-app report is not a substitute for law enforcement in serious cases.

CONVERSATION SCRIPT FOR PARENTS

"Instagram changed some of its rules for accounts like yours — there's now a time limit and a nighttime block built in. I'm not adding those myself, the app already has them. What I do want to see is who you're talking to that I don't already know in real life. If anyone online ever asks you to keep a secret from me, or move the conversation somewhere else, that's the one thing I need you to tell me — you're never in trouble for telling me that."

QUICK REFERENCE CHECKLIST

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| ☐ Account confirmed as a real Teen Account | ☐ Parental Supervision linked (with teen's consent) |
| ☐ Profile set to private | ☐ Teen knows how to report, not just block |
| ☐ 2-hour daily time limit confirmed active | ☐ Teen understands the "move the conversation" red flag |
| ☐ Overnight block (midnight–6am) confirmed on | ☐ Regular check-in conversation scheduled |